

Cave temples

Dating from the second century BCE to about 460–480 CE, some 30 rock-cut Buddhist cave temples were built at Ajanta, near the city of Aurangabad in the Indian state of Maharashtra. Nearby lie the Ellora caves (opposite), built during the sixth to ninth centuries by the Rashtrakuta dynasty and comprising Hindu, Buddhist and Jain temples. The Badami cave temples in the Bagalkot district, meanwhile, comprise four caves, all carved out of the soft sandstone cliff.

Today some 1,200 Indian cave temples survive, built chiefly between the fifth and tenth centuries, in fairly close proximity to each other. Relics from a period marked by religious harmony, most caves consist of viharas or monasteries: multi-storey buildings carved high up and deep inside mountains, comprising living quarters, kitchens, prayer halls and verandas. They feature complex construction methods, with integral pillars, intricate room systems and fine, detailed carving – not to mention the accurate removal of thousands of tonnes of rock.

